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TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Voice & Verse

The Literature of the Harlem Renaissance · Grades 5–8 · ELA

THE 35 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	15 min	5 min
HOOK	TEACH	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will analyze the literary techniques of Harlem Renaissance writers, understand how writers used their craft as both art and activism, evaluate primary source texts as historical evidence, and develop their own voice in response to Renaissance themes.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RI.6.8 / RI.7.8	Trace and evaluate arguments; assess credibility and relevance of evidence
CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RL.6.4 / RL.7.4	Determine the meaning of words and phrases including figurative language
CCSS.ELA-LITERACY W.7.3	Write narratives that draw on real or imagined experiences using effective literary technique

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Student handouts
- Access to exhibition's Harlem in Words poetry workshop
- Optional: printed or projected excerpts from public domain Harlem Renaissance texts

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

Write on the board: *"What does your voice sound like on paper?"* Ask students to write for 90 seconds — anything, no rules. Then ask: *"Does your writing sound like YOU, or does it sound like how you think you're supposed to write?"* This is exactly the question Harlem Renaissance writers were asking.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 10 MINUTES

"The writers of the Harlem Renaissance made a radical decision: they would write in their own voices. Not the formal English of white academic tradition. Their own rhythms, their own vernacular, their own truth. Langston Hughes wrote poetry that used the rhythms of jazz and blues. Zora Neale Hurston captured the dialect of Black Southern speech in her novels. They were saying: our way of speaking is not a deficiency. It is literature."

"This was a political act as much as an artistic one. In a country that told Black Americans their culture was inferior, writing beautiful, powerful, innovative literature was an act of resistance. Every poem published, every novel reviewed in major newspapers, every prize won was evidence that the dominant narrative was wrong."

ACTIVITY · 15 MINUTES

Differentiated work time

Distribute student handouts. Students self-select their challenge level. Circulate with targeted questions to push thinking at each level.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Scaffolded activities with vocabulary support and structured response frames. Students engage with core content with guidance.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Independent grade-level analysis. Students apply concepts, make connections, and express their own thinking without heavy scaffolding.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Extended critical thinking and research. Students synthesize across sources, evaluate arguments, and produce original analysis or creative work.

Note: Red level activities may extend beyond the lesson period — they are designed to continue at home.

CLOSING · 5 MINUTES

Bring the class back together. Ask 2–3 students from different levels to share one thing they discovered or created. Close with:

"The Harlem Renaissance wasn't just a historical event. It was a demonstration that ordinary people — with talent, community, and courage — can create something that changes the world. The work you've done today connects you to that tradition."

ASSESSMENT

Formative: Circulate during work time and check for understanding of the core concepts. Use targeted questions to assess depth of thinking.

Exit ticket: *"What is one connection between the Harlem Renaissance and ELA?"*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, visit the Mini Museum to experience the phonograph, Jazz Lab, Great Migration Map, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a class visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition at **minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance**